

INTERVIEW | **M.K. STALIN**

"The high command never gives posts by violating rules"

The succession battle in the DMK brings ugly sibling rivalry to the fore. In an interview to INDIA TODAY, deputy chief minister M.K. Stalin speaks about the party, its prospects and his plans for the people. Excerpts from the interview.

Q. Your father holds the top post in the party as well as in the Government. In this milieu, how did you handle the criticism when you became the deputy chief minister last year?

A. The party, Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), has faced countless trials, obstacles and crisis to rule the state. The party high command never gives any posts to any one by violating any rule. So no criticisms were raised when I took charge. Even if there were, I chose to ignore them.

Q. There are charges that the party remained silent when thousands of Tamils were massacred in Sri Lanka.

A. The DMK is the only party that showed keen interest in resolving the Sri Lankan Tamil issue. The party's electoral victory in the last Lok Sabha elections proves it.

Q. The DMK registered astounding gains in the Lok Sabha elections and captured eight seats in the successive by-elections. Was 2009 the party's best year?

A. It is the "people's best period. The fruit of government's welfare schemes have reached the grassroots level and people rewarded us suitably in the elections.



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Q. Electoral victories are often

bought by bribing voters. Isn't it?

A. As a matter of policy, I don't believe in bribing voters. We can only get people's support when we tell them about what we have done for them and what we plan to do for them. Our party is doing just that.

Q. What is the status of the DMK's relationship with the Congress?

A. The coalition continues to be stronger.

Q. What is your opinion on caste-based parties and caste politics?

A. It is natural that movements to fight for the rights of downtrodden will always sprout in society. But when a movement sows hatred, it becomes anti-human. When we unite by forgetting the caste tags, we become more humanistic.

Q. The DMK came to power with its slogan for a separate Tamil state, "Atheism, Tamil nationalism". But all its ideologies have been diluted or have been dropped. What is the ideology of the party today?

A. We didn't call for atheism but we stand by our ideology of one God, one mankind and the party firmly believes that caste, race or language should not be used to subjugate Tamils. As a result of our intensive fight, today we have achieved classical status for Tamil.

band of loyalists. In this context, it would not be easy for him to run the party as well as the Government. In a recent interview, Azhagiri said, "After Annadurai, Kalaigarnar (Karunanidhi) is my only leader. While he is around, there is no necessity to think about others as leaders. And after him, I won't accept anybody as my leader in the DMK." Such statements hint that the road ahead for Stalin is far from smooth. Though a patch up with the



Maran brothers—Sun TV Networks' Kalanidhi Maran and the Union Textiles Minister Dayanidhi Maran—had been worked out by Karunanidhi, the Azhagiri factor continues to bother him. Added to this is the fact that Kanimozhi looks up to Azhagiri and not Stalin. "I cannot help to secure anybody's future. But as an elder brother, my affection and support will always be there for Kanimozhi," Azhagiri said.

Any effort to place Stalin as the head of the Government and the party is likely to be met with stiff resistance. Azhagiri is eyeing the party chief's post and may be generous enough to allow his younger brother Stalin to hold fort in the government. But Stalin isn't will-